



Standout players: World No. 12 Bernadette Szocs was one of the star attractions at this year's UTT. VIJAY SONEJI

tournament was being held in Bhavnagar, 170 km from Ahmedabad, which reduced the chances of local players and fans attending UTT in the opening phase.

However, fixtures involving tournament debutant Kolkata ThunderBlades had a vibrant atmosphere, thanks to an enthusiastic cheering squad and dholwalas supporting the baby-blue-clad team. The co-owners — Ketan Jain and Rajat Kumar, both former national-level players — set a fan engagement template later adopted by the Patriots.

The season ended on a relatively upbeat note, with around 500 spectators attending each of the two semifinals and a near-capacity crowd present for the final.

Also, with 20 million viewers tuning in across TV and OTT platforms last season, and a broadcast deal with JioStar running until 2027, the organisers may not be overly concerned about live audience numbers and might let that aspect evolve organically.

From a talent perspective, UTT 6

featured top international names like World No. 12 Bernadette Szocs, World No. 17 Adriana Díaz, World No. 25 Quadri Aruna, World No. 34 Ricardo Walther and World No. 42 Britt Eerland. For the first time since the inaugural edition in 2017, a Chinese player — Fan Siqi — participated. She was the most valuable player at UTT's first-ever auction in April.

For India, established players such as Harmeet Desai (Dempo Goa Challengers), Sreeja Akula (Jaipur Patriots), and G. Sathiyam (Dabang Delhi TTC) featured, but there were notable absentees. Ahmedabad SG Pipers' Manika Batra was ruled out two days before the tournament due to injury. Manav Thakkar and Manush Shah — the country's top two male paddlers and both Gujaratis — missed out due to commitments in foreign leagues. For

a league built as a platform to boost Indian table tennis, their absence was a blow. At the same time, eight Indian players made their UTT debuts, with several putting in standout performances. U Mumba's Akash Pal, who didn't get a game in UTT 5, justified his retention by becoming the best Indian doubles player this season. P.B. Abhinandh, a 17-year-old from Chennai and a Mumbai franchise member, shocked Olympian Izaac Quek on debut, bagged a crucial game in the semifinal against the Challengers, and secured the title-winning point in the final. Youngsters Ankur Bhattacharjee, Yashaswini Ghorpade, and Diya Chitale also strengthened their claims as rising stars. A new Under-15 event titled Dream UTT Juniors, won by the ThunderBlades, was a welcome addition.

« Top Indian paddlers Manav Thakkar and Manush Shah missed out due to overseas league commitments, hurting UTT's Indian focus »